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Condiments

3.5 Condiments

There are eleven types of condiments in the Bible: caper, coriander, cumin, dill, dove's dung, mallow, mint, mustard, nigella, orache, and rue.

Caper (caper bush, caper berry)

3.5.1 Caper (caper bush, caper berry)

Reference:"

Hebrew אֶבְיוֹנָה (’aviyonah) ECC 12:5

Discussion:

Caper flower, bud (Iorsh (Wikimedia Commons))In the delightful description of old age in ECC 12:0, a string of metaphors is followed by the clause "desire [’aviyonah in Hebrew] fails." The word ’aviyonah only occurs once in the Bible, so there has been much debate over its meaning. The Septuagint translators took the first meaning of the word and rendered it "caper berry," referring to the spicy tasting bud of a small bush (Capparis spinosa) common in the Middle East. The Syriac and the Vulgate have the same rendering, and so do NAB and GECL. GW,

JB, and NJPSV are similar with “caper bush,” and so are NEB and REB with “caper-buds.” La Nouvelle Bible Segond and La Sainte Bible: Version Synodale say simply “caper,” and FRCL uses the generic term “spices.”

Caper buds (© Yuvalr (Wikimedia Commons))Jews and others in ancient times used the caper berry and especially the pickled bud of the bush to increase the appetite, and the words meaning “desire” found in Greek and Hebrew dictionaries seems to be based on the association of capers and desire. In the Middle Ages Europeans considered the caper berry as an aphrodisiac; Moldenke does not find evidence that it was so used in ancient times.

A number of prominent botanists are convinced that the Hebrew word ’ezov in the Pentateuch does not refer to the hyssop plant (so Septuagint) or even the marjoram (“Syrian hyssop”), but to the caper bush, which grows in Egypt and the Sinai Desert, where the Israelites were instructed to use it for the Passover ceremony. It also grows in the cracks of city walls, fitting the description of Solomon’s knowledge of botany as described in 1KI 5:13 (4.33). Some even say a stick from the caper bush would have been long enough to fit the reference in JHN 19:29 (hussōpos in Greek), where soldiers lifted a sponge to Jesus’ lips on a stick. However, Zohary and others, on the basis of etymology, believe the words ’ezov and hussōpos most likely refer to the marjoram plant. I agree. See also the discussion on these words under 5.2.4 Marjoram.

Description:

Caper bush (© Ray Pritz (UBS))In open areas the caper bush can grow as a bush to a meter (3 feet) in height, but more often it is found sprawling over rocks and broken-down walls, and hanging from cliffs and the cracks in outside walls. It has a beautiful flower with three purplish-white petals and many long, curved purple stamens. The leaves are round and gray-green in color. The flowers open in the evening and wilt by the following morning, eventually producing a stalk with a berry containing many seeds.

Special significance:

Caper flower (© Klearchos Kapoutsis (Wikimedia Commons))People in the Middle East and many other places soak the buds of the caper in vinegar and eat them with meat. This process, called “pickling,” was already being done before the time of Christ in Israel, Egypt, and Arabia. Middle Easterners also ate the fruit of the caper bush, which was also spicy. Now pickled caper buds are popular throughout Europe, especially in France. Ancient Greek writers mention the caper often. It was used to get rid of stomach gas.

Translation:

The caper bush is common throughout the Mediterranean region. Another species known as Capparis sodado grows in East Africa (Sudan), Arabia, and southern India. It is an almost leafless spiny shrub and has edible berries. Four other members of the genus Capparis are found in South America (mostly in Argentina, southern Brazil, Columbia, Paraguay, and Venezuela) with the names Pan y agua and Sacha-poroto. There the fruit is eaten but is apparently not as popular as the caper is in southern Europe. The reference to the caper in ECC 12:5 is part of a long string of metaphors, so the translation of “caper” will depend on how the translators have dealt with “almond tree” and the other metaphors, either leaving them literal, or “domesticating” them by using local equivalents or a generic term. Our preference here would be to keep the language poetical by substituting a local plant with the same function, in this case, something that stimulates the taste buds. Here we want to express the old person’s inability to enjoy spicy food. If the translation is to be more literal, an English transliteration could be used by rendering the whole clause as “the kaparis no longer makes you/him salivate [or, no longer bites/tickles],” with a footnote indicating that kaparis is a Jewish spice. Other transliterations could be made from Arabic assaf, alkabara; French capre; Portuguese alcaparras; and Spanish alcaparron, caparra. RSV says “desire

fails," which is a nonfigurative rendering of the Hebrew. If this option is followed, a footnote may be appreciated, stating that the Hebrew refers to a spicy food in this passage.

Coriander

3.5.2 Coriander

References:

Hebrew גַּד (gad) EXO 16:31, NUM 11:7

Discussion:

Coriander bush (© Niepokój Zbigniew (Wikimedia Commons))According to EXO 16:31, the miraculous food called "manna" that God sent to the wandering Israelites in the desert was "like coriander seed, white." Coriander Coriandrum sativum did in fact grow in Egypt and the Holy Land. However, its seed is not very white, but more brown or gray, and the NUM 11:7 tells us that the color was that of bdellium, of which we know almost nothing for certain. Further, the Septuagint has the Greek word korion, which is not coriander. The Arabic name gidda, the cognate of the Hebrew word gad, refers to a different plant, namely wormwood. To complicate the matter further, EXO 16:14 describes manna as "flaky," whereas coriander seeds are spherical or egg-shaped.

In view of these difficulties, Zohary expresses doubt as to whether the word gad actually refers to the plant we now know as coriander. He speculates that early translators, not knowing what gad referred to, took the Punic word goid for coriander, and made the association between gad and coriander. The writer would have done us a favor if he had said "like coriander flowers," which can be white, but unfortunately the text has "seed." Maybe

an early narrator or scribe made a mistake in transmitting the text. Could the Hebrew word perach (“flower”) perhaps have been replaced by zera‘ (“seed”)?

However, it is possible that coriander seed really was intended, and that the point of comparison between manna and coriander seeds was their size, which is about 4 millimeters (3/16 inch) in diameter, the size of a peppercorn (black pepper seed). (Thus REB and NAB have “like coriander seed, but white.”) Another possibility is that the writer was thinking of the way the seeds cluster, or of their firmness. We are told in NUM 11:8 that the people pounded the manna in mortars and ground it in mills, suggesting some degree of hardness.

Description:

Coriander seeds (© Sanjay Acharya (Wikimedia Commons))The coriander plant is around 60 centimeters (2 feet) in height, the upper leaves being finely divided and the lower ones broad, with tiny white or reddish flowers, and a strong odor. The seeds are oily, brown or gray, and about the size of small peas. The leaves and seeds were used in ancient times in cooking, and are still used for soup and salads up to the present. The fragrant oil from the seeds is sometimes used in making perfume and medicine.

Special significance:

As discussed above, coriander is used to describe the appearance of manna. Unfortunately we don’t know whether the point of comparison is the color, shape, size, or texture. Coriander is common in Israel and Egypt, and all the way across to Iraq and India. The leaves are used as a spice for food and also in perfume. But all of that is irrelevant if the point of comparison has to do with the seed.

Translation:

A Handbook on Exodus says that it is the shape and size of the coriander seeds that are the point of comparison between coriander and manna, but since we are not sure, it may be difficult to find a cultural equivalent. So

translators can give a generic rendering, as GNB has done (“like a small white seed”), omitting reference to coriander (but including it in a footnote). It is also possible to follow REB and NAB (“like coriander seed, but white”), which disassociate the seed from the color. If this is done, translators may transliterate “coriander” from a major language (for example, French koriyandro, korion; Arabic kuzbara; Portuguese coentro; Spanish cilantro) or from the Hebrew gad.

The Septuagint injects the Greek word for coriander (korion) from EXO 16:31 back into verse 14. Some versions have followed this, but it is not particularly helpful.

Cumin (cummin)

3.5.3 Cumin (cummin)

References:

Hebrew כַּמֹּן (kammon) ISA 28:25, ISA 28:27, ISA 28:27

Greek κύμινον (kuminon) MAT 23:23

Discussion:

Cumin (Franz Eugen Köhler (Wikimedia Commons))Two controversial seeds are mentioned in ISA 28:25; ISA 28:25; ISA 28:27; ISA 28:27: qetsach (see 3.5.9 Nigella (kalonji, black cumin, black seed, charnushka, nutmeg flower)) and kammon. The seeds referred to as kammon are probably those of cumin (also spelled “cummin”), which takes its

Latin scientific name Cuminum cyminum from the Greek. It was common to the Mediterranean area (especially in Syria) and Ethiopia, possibly even native to Egypt, where it was used in cooking and also as medicine.

Description:

The cumin plant belongs to the same family as the carrot. It branches abundantly from the base and has similar leaves and flowers. However, the seeds have a much sharper smell than those of the carrot. Cumin is planted and harvested each year, reaching a height of perhaps 50–60 centimeters (20–24 inches).

Special significance:

In ISA 28:25; ISA 28:25; ISA 28:27; ISA 28:27 cumin is cited with other garden plants to show how different plants and their fruits require different care and processing. (Cumin and nigella, for example, are more easily damaged in threshing than hard cereal grains would be). It is part of a parable Isaiah tells to the proud Israelite leaders who thought they knew how God deals with people. Interestingly, farmers in Malta still thresh cumin in the way described by Isaiah. In New Testament times the Jewish authorities were not sure whether cumin should be tithed since it was not mentioned specifically in the Mosaic Law. They took no chances and insisted that people tithe their cumin. But then they ignored the need for justice and mercy, thereby incurring the condemnation of Jesus in MAT 23:23.

Translation:

Translators will either transliterate “cumin” from a major language (for example, Spanish comino; Portuguese cuminho, cominho; Arabic kamun, Swahili jamda, kisibiti, jira), or they can seek an equivalent, depending on what they have done with the other terms (“mint” and “dill”) in MAT 23:23. Simplified versions may use a generic phrase such as “all kinds of small garden plants.”

Dill

3.5.4 Dill

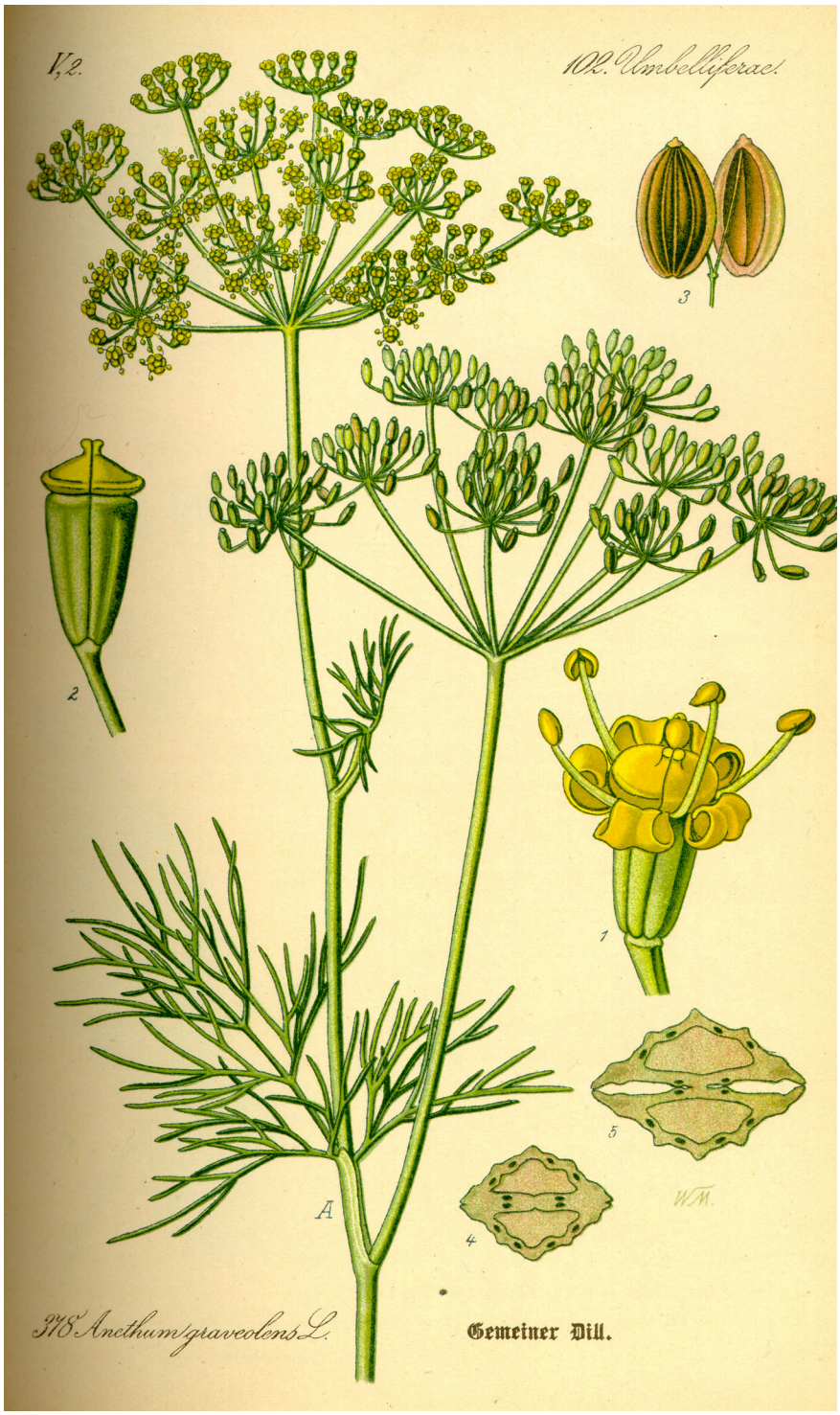
Reference:”

Greek ἄνηθον (anēthon) MAT 23:23

Discussion:

Dill flowers (© PatríciaR (Wikimedia Commons))KJV translates the Greek word anēthon in MAT 23:23 as “anise,” but scholars now agree that the plant Jesus refers to is the Dill Anethum graveolens, a garden herb. The translation of the Hebrew word qetsach as “dill” by RSV, NEB, and REB in ISA 28:25; ISA 28:27; ISA 28:27 is now seen as erroneous. (see 3.5.9 Nigella (kalonji, black cumin, black seed, charnushka, nutmeg flower).)

Description:



Dill plant (Prof. Dr. Otto Wilhelm Thomé Flora von Deutschland, Österreich und der Schweiz 1885, Gera, Germany)Dill is an annual plant that can reach 50 centimeters (20 inches) in height. Like the carrot, parsley and fennel, it has fine leaves. Its yellow flowers form a shape like a covered cup. The leaves and seeds have a pleasant, spicy smell.

Special significance:

As in the case of cumin (3.5.3) and mint (3.5.7), Jesus used dill to condemn the skewed values of the religious leaders, who were blind to the misfortunes of the poor but fastidiously tithed even small garden seeds.

Translation:

Dill is known in western Asia and in India as well as in Europe and America. Depending on what is done with the other plants in MAT 23:23, namely mint and cumin, the translator may choose to transliterate “dill” from the original Greek anēthon or from a major language (for example, French aneth; Spanish anega, eneldo, aneto; Portuguese endro, aneto, funcho; Arabic bazrul, shibit, sjama). It is debatable whether the context here is rhetorical or not, so transliteration of the three species is acceptable, although substituting cultural equivalents is also possible and effective. It is important to keep in mind the parallel passage of 2KI 6:25, which does not include dill. An American Translation (AT), Mft, and Weymouth use “dill” here, as do the modern English versions.

Dove’s dung (Star of Bethlehem)

3.5.5 Dove’s dung (Star of Bethlehem)

Reference:”

Hebrew חֲרָאִים, חרצנים (chareyonim or chartsonim) 2KI 6:25

Discussion:

Star of Bethlehem plant (Iorsh (Wikimedia Commons))In the story of the siege of Samaria, we read in 2KI 6:25 that “the fourth part of a kab of dove’s dung [was sold] for five shekels of silver.” The Samarians must have been desparate, but even so, they were probably not eating dove’s dung, and three possibilities are given by the experts:

1. The original writer wrote the Hebrew word chartsonim (“wild onion”) and the text was copied wrongly to read chareyonim (“dove’s dung”). NJB and NAB take this position.
2. Dove’s dung was the name of a common plant (footnotes in GNB and NLT). Possible candidates for the plant called “dove’s dung” are:

a. locust bean, or carob (NIV, REB, NJPSV footnote);

b. the bulb of a flower (Linnaeus, Josephus).

3. Real dove’s dung was processed and made into a salt substitute (footnote in GECL [1982]).

Hepper doubts that dove’s dung would refer to the carob or locust bean. He finds option 2b more likely, saying that chareyonim refers to the bulbs of the Star of Bethlehem Ornithogalum narbonense, which, according to historians, were sold during the siege of Samaria at about two ounces of silver for a cup. The name Linnaeus

gave to the Star of Bethlehem plant is “ornitho-galum.” This name literally means bird-milk, suggesting that the botanist was perhaps aware of the connection to a name like “bird dung.” Only one of the many species of the genus Ornithogalum is edible; all the others are poisonous. Having lived in Nigeria where the leaf of a plant called “bird dung” is a popular soup ingredient (called kashin tsuntsu in Hausa), I am prepared to believe option 2. Anderson, Zohary, and Hareuveni do not mention “dove’s dung,” perhaps on the assumption that it is not a plant.

Description:

Star of Bethlehem (© Hectonichus (Wikimedia Commons))The Star of Bethlehem plant grows to about 25 centimeters (10 inches) from a circular bunch of narrow leaves at the base. Its sweet-smelling white flowers have six petals and grow on a stalk. They appear late in the spring and last only about 2 weeks before wilting. The flowers open in the morning and usually close by noon.

Special significance:

Whatever “dove’s dung” may be in 2KI 6:25, it was intended to illustrate the desperate condition of the inhabitants of Samaria during the siege, when even something barely edible was sold at an exorbitant price.

Translation:

For “dove’s dung” the name of some marginally edible market item, or a phrase such as “wild onions” would be appropriate in JOB 6:6. The use of a commonly used measurement and coin instead of “kab” and “shekel” will help get the point across. The parallelism of “dove’s dung” with “donkey’s head” will also help, as long as the value of the silver is expressed meaningfully. If the translator substitutes a local object for “dove’s dung,” it should be a very low-value commodity. The Septuagint translated “dove’s dung” literally. Those who wish to follow a literal rendering, as in RSV and NLT, should have a footnote stating that “dove’s dung” could be a plant. Possibilities for transliteration are French ornithogale, aspergette; Portuguese ornitogalos; and Spanish ornitogala.

Mallow

3.5.6 Mallow

References:

Hebrew חַלָּמוּת (challamuth) JOB 24:24

Hebrew כֹּל (kol) JOB 6:6

Discussion:

Common purslane (© Júlio Reis (Wikimedia Commons))Responding to the unhelpful and unkind words of his so-called friends, Job asks the following in JOB 6:6: “Can that which is tasteless be eaten without salt? Is there any taste in the slime of the purslane [challamuth in Hebrew]?” The main ideas of these two parallel lines are: a) tasteless things need salt, and b) the slime of challamuth is tasteless.

There is much debate whether or not the Hebrew word challamuth refers to a plant at all here. Some versions render it as “white of an egg” (GNB, NLT, GW) or “egg white” (NIV), and one commentator suggests it could refer to “whitewash,” “plaster,” or even “one who has died.” However, on the basis of Arabic cognate word lachamut and the Mishnaic tradition, Zohary holds that challamuth may refer to one or more plants from the Malvaceae family, namely Mallow Malva sylvestris, Mallow Malva nicaeensis, or Hollyhock Alcea setosa. REB has “mallow.” Some species in this family are in fact eaten by goats and are used by Bedouins in cooking.

However, Hepper identifies challamuth as the Common Purslane Portulaca oleracea, another plant used in salad and as medicine. Moldenke does not find a plant at all in JOB 6:6.

Description:

Common mallow (© Alvesgaspar (Wikimedia Commons))The common mallow is a small plant growing to around 25 centimeters (10 inches) high. It has round, lobed or heart-shaped leaves with long stems, and produces a purple flower.

Special significance:

If the word challamuth refers to a plant, it is one that represents something tasteless and slimy in JOB 6:6. Job describes the words of his companions as tasteless and unhelpful like the slimy challamuth. Not surprisingly, Bildad responds in kind in JOB 8:1, saying that Job's own words are "a great wind."

Translation:

JOB 6:6: Given the wide range of opinion among the experts, the translator's simplest option for rendering challamuth is to follow a major version used in the area. Since the context is rhetorical, translators striving for poetic impact may look for a cultural equivalent—a plant that is known to be tasteless, or something else unpleasant like a raw egg white.

An important question here is this: Is challamuth something totally inedible, or is it something that is edible if you put salt on it? In Africa, where okra and roselle are well known (and slimy), such a plant could be used. However, translators should be careful since both okra and rosella are eaten frequently in soup and are considered delicious! A Handbook on The Book of Job gives about equal weight to "purslane," "mallow," "milkweed," and "egg white," and finally commends "egg white" as in GNB. However, if translators wish to take challamuth as a plant, we offer the following basic models based on two alternative assumptions:

1. If the Hebrew words tafel ("that which is tasteless") and rir challamuth ("slime of the purslane") refer to totally inedible substances, two possible renderings of JOB 6:6 are:

"No one could swallow what I have been given to eat. It is like plaster, like the sap of milkweed [or, euphorbia cactus / mallow]."

"No one can eat whitewash [or, plaster/sand/straw/cotton]. There is no taste in milkweed sap [or, euphorbia sap]."

2. If these Hebrew words refer to edible but tasteless substances, two possible models are:

"No one could swallow what I have been given to eat. It is like pap [or, raw cassava or some local very plain food without much taste] without salt, like the sap of mallow [or, the juice of some tasteless but edible plant]."

"No one can eat pap [or, raw cassava or some local flat-tasting food such as rice] without salt. There is no taste in the sap of mallow [or, the juice of some tasteless but edible plant.]"

Any of these renderings prepare the reader for Job's next line: "My appetite refuses to touch them."

JOB 24:24: According to HOTTP, the Hebrew word kakol rendered "like the mallow" can either mean "like all" or "like the umbel." (An umbel is a flower cluster that has a common axis.) If it is true that the Hebrew verb following kakol actually means "to close up," then "umbel" is odd because umbellate flowers, to my knowledge, do not "close up." So, if translators follow HOTTP here, the meaning "like all" is recommended. NIV follows this sense by rendering the second line of this verse as "they are brought low and gathered up like all others" (similarly LB, NAB, Wolfers).

The Septuagint translates kol as the plant called "saltwort," according to Pope. If one normally follows the Septuagint, "saltwort" is preferable to "mallow." If a transliteration from English is necessary, "saltwort" (NJB) or "saltplant" is more technically correct than "mallow" (RSV, NJPSV). See 3.5.10 Orache (saltwort).

GNB and CEV render kol as "weeds" to avoid the issue of the identity of the plant, but of course this rendering loses some color in its generality.

Mint

3.5.7 Mint

References:

Greek ἡδύοσμον (hēduosmon) MAT 23:23, LUK 11:42

Discussion:

Horse mint (© Isidre blanc (Wikimedia Commons))The Horse Mint Mentha longifolia is the most common of the mint plants in the Holy Land, found on the banks of streams throughout the country. The Jews called it dandanah, a Hebrew word that does not occur in the Old Testament. They served its leaves along with milk and cucumbers, made a hot drink by boiling them, or used them, as the Romans and Greeks also did, in medicine and cooking. According to Moldenke, people scattered mint leaves on the floors of synagogues, and the fragrance was released as people entered and stepped on them.

Description:

The horse mint is larger than the other kinds of mint, reaching up to 2 meters (7 feet). It has small, soft leaves with sawlike margins, and lavender-colored flowers.

Special significance:

In MAT 23:23 and LUK 11:42 Jesus accuses the Pharisees of legalistically tithing not only from their major food crops—olives, dates and wheat, for example—but even from the leaves they pluck for their soup, including mint, and then ignoring issues of justice and poverty.

Translation:

At least twenty-five kinds of mint are found in temperate areas of the world. It is well known in West Africa as an additive to tea. Depending on what translators do with the other species mentioned in MAT 23:23 and LUK 11:42 (dill, cumin, and rue), if they do not have these species locally, they may transliterate “mint” from a

major language (for example, French menthe; Spanish menta; Portuguese hortelã, hisopo, ervadeSãoLourenco; Swahili mnaanaa). In simplified versions they may cover all these species with a generic phrase such as “all kinds of little plants in the garden.”

Mustard

3.5.8 Mustard

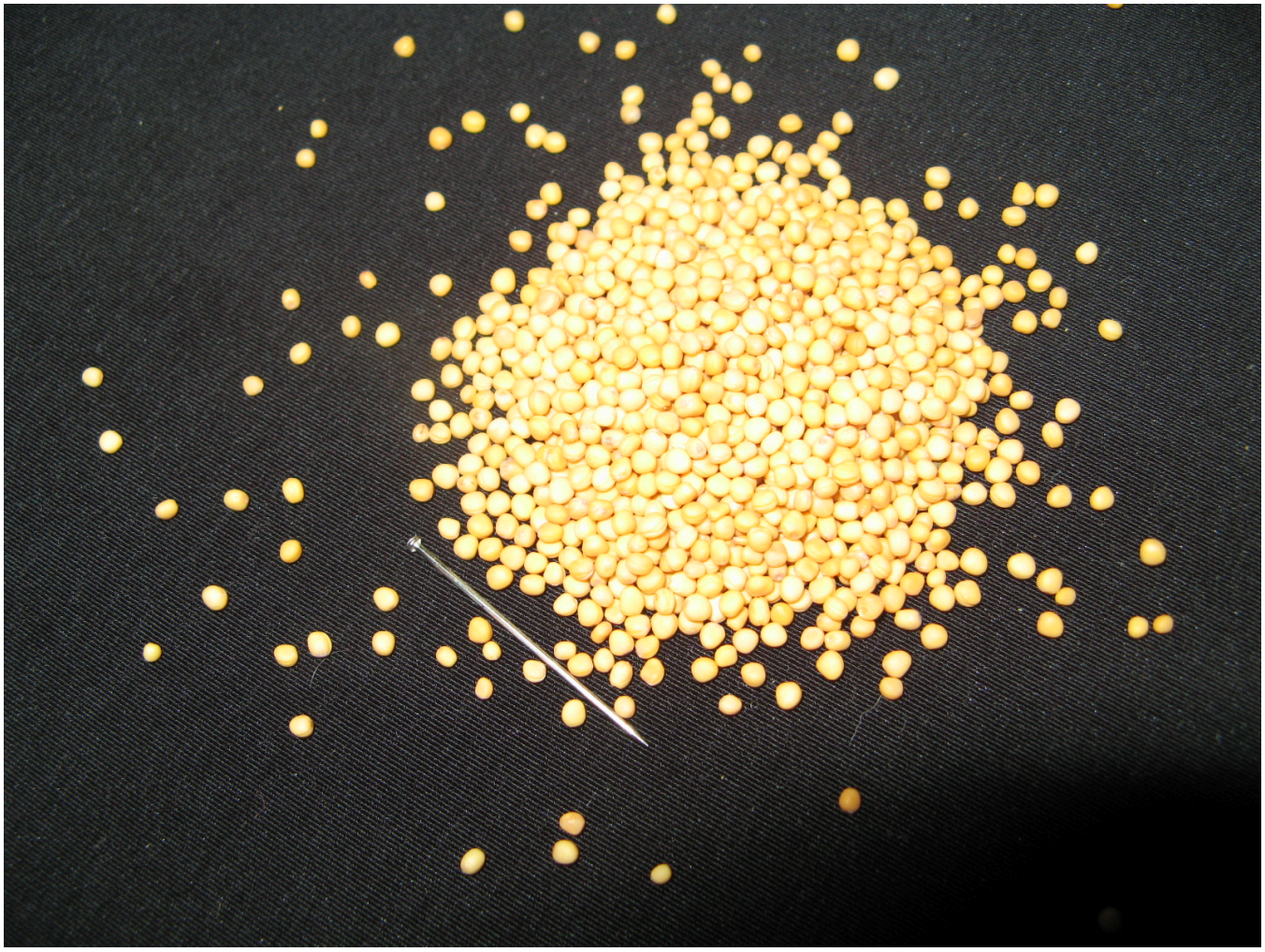
References:

Greek σίναπι (sinapi) MAT 13:31, MAT 17:20, MRK 4:31, LUK 13:19, LUK 17:6

Discussion:

White mustard plant (© H. Zell (Wikimedia Commons))There is by no means full agreement about the precise identity of the plant in Jesus' famous references to the mustard seed. Two types of mustard grow in the Holy Land and probably grew there in Bible times: Black Mustard Brassica nigra and White Mustard Sinapis alba. Zohary and Moldenke favor the former. Hepper leaves it open. Both species were either cultivated or gathered in Bible times, probably more for the oil, which was used in medicine and cooking, than as a spice. Both types are cultivated today.

Description:



Mustard seeds with pin (© Ray Pritz (UBS))Mustard plants are related to some other well-known food plants, such as collards, broccoli, cauliflower, Brussels sprouts, rutabaga, and Chinese cabbage. They are planted and harvested each year. They grow to 2 meters (7 feet) in height and have branches like a tree. At the ends of the branches there are bright yellow flowers with four petals, like nearly all the members of the Brassicaceae family. The seeds are small among the seeds of garden plants, being about 2 millimeters (1/12 inch) in diameter, but they are not by any means the smallest of all seeds.

Special significance:

The point of the mustard seed parable of Jesus is that something small can produce something very large and complex, like the kingdom of God, or like the amazing deeds of a person with faith.

Translation:

At least thirty kinds of mustard are known in the world, twenty-one of them in Europe. Others are found in Northeast Africa, India, Japan, and China. The quality in focus in all of the Gospel references is the smallness of

the mustard seed compared to the large size of the resulting plant. The translator must keep that in mind, even if a relative of the mustard is found. If no effective equivalent is available, it will be necessary to transliterate “mustard” from a major language (for example, French moutarde, Spanish mostaza, Portuguese mostarda, Arabic khardalaswad, Swahili haradali).

Nigella (kalonji, black cumin, black seed, charnushka, nutmeg flower)

3.5.9 Nigella (kalonji, black cumin, black seed, charnushka, nutmeg flower)

References:

Hebrew קֶצַח (qetsach) ISA 28:25, ISA 28:27, ISA 28:27

Discussion:

Nigella plants (Franz Eugen Köhler, Köhler’s Medizinal-Pflanzen)The English versions of ISA 28:25; ISA 28:27; ISA 28:27 reveal the confusion of the translators who have encountered the Hebrew word qetsach. It has been rendered “fitches” (KJV), “dill” (RSV, GNB, CEV, NLT, NEB, REB), “fennel” (JB, NJB), and “caraway” (NIV). Against all of these renderings, Zohary confidently asserts that the word qetsach refers to the Nigella plant Nigella sativa, also

called by the names nutmeg flower, black cumin, black seed, charnushka, and kalonji. (The Hebrew word kammon in these verses refers to the ordinary cumin; see 3.5.3 Cumin (cummin)) Hepper agrees, apparently supported by Post, Moldenke, and others. The Aramaic and Arabic equivalent is qatscha. Jews, Arabs, and Europeans use nigella seeds to decorate cakes and bread up to the present. It is also used as a spice in cooking.

Description:

Nigella is planted and harvested annually. It grows to around 30 centimeters (1 foot) in height and has a lacy leaf like dill or carrot and a greenish-blue flower with five petals. The base of the flower becomes a seedpod that contains many round, black, sharp-smelling seeds.

Special significance:

Nigella is used by Isaiah as one of several species in a parable he tells to the leaders of Israel. A farmer, he says, does not destroy the results of one season’s work while preparing for that of the next season. This is spoken to know-it-all scoffers who claim that God’s ways are completely fixed. Against that Isaiah says that God’s ways are according to the conditions of his creatures, as a farmer plants and harvests according to the needs of the various crops.

Translation:

The abundance of names for nigella is an indication of its popularity around the world. Fortunately the Latin name nigella is now replacing the confusing name “black cumin.” This is good because cumin is a totally different plant. Likewise, “nutmeg flower” and “black caraway” are losing favor. So translators can avoid the confusion brought on by the English by transliterating from Latin (nigella), French and Dutch (nigelle), Spanish (agenuz, neguilla, arañuel), German (Nigella, Schwartzkümmel [literally “black seed”]), Hebrew (qetsach), Persian (kalanji), or Arabic (ḥabbet as suda, kamun aswad, shuniz). In Amharic nigella is tikur azmud, in Mandarin hei zhong cao, and in Indonesian jinten hitam.

Orache (saltwort)

3.5.10 Orache (saltwort)

Reference:”

Hebrew מַלּוּחַ (malluach) JOB 30:4

Discussion:

Orache (© Karsten Niehaus (Academic.com))JOB 30:4 describes an unfortunate group of people who in their hunger pluck malluach and the leaves of bushes to eat. Although a few botanists render malluach as “mallow” (so RSV), Zohary, following Moldenke and others, holds that malluach refers to the Shrubby Orache Atriplex halimus, also called saltbush. The Septuagint uses the Greek word halimōn (coming from halmē “salted”), which refers to a species of saltwort or orache. Orache is abundant especially in salty areas in the desert and on the shores of the Mediterranean Sea and the Dead Sea. If we follow the Septuagint, orache or saltwort is also appropriate in JOB 24:24 (see 3.5.6 Mallow).

Description:

Shrubby orache (© Krzysztof Ziarnek, Kenraiz (Wikimedia Commons))The orache plant grows up to 2 meters (7 feet) tall, with many branches emerging at ground level. Its stem and branches have small silver-gray leaves covered with tiny hairs. Its leaves are edible but salty. Orache belongs to the goosefoot family (Chenopodiaceae), which includes spinach.

Translation:

Given the uncertainty of the identification of the Hebrew word malluach, translators may be excused for taking a generic route here and translating “coarse leaves” (NLT), “tasteless shrubs” (CEV), “desert plants,” (NCV), or “plants of the desert” (GNB). NIV says “salt herbs,” which makes reference to the salt-tolerant nature of the orache reflected in the Septuagint and in the alternative name “saltwort.” However, it is equally appropriate to supply a species name here, and if the translator is so inclined, a transliteration of “orache” can be made from a major language (for example, English orash, French arroche), or a word like “saltbush” can be coined. “Mallow” should be not be used, since it refers to a different plant found in JOB 6:6 (see 3.5.6 Mallow).

Rue

3.5.11 Rue

Reference:”

Greek πήγανον (pēganon) LUK 11:42

Discussion:

Rue flowers (© Zeynel Cebeci (Wikimedia Commons))In the Holy Land at the time of Jesus there was only one wild species of rue common, the Mountain Rue Ruta chalepensis, and it is likely the one referred to by Jesus in his rebuke of the Pharisees in LUK 11:42. The very similar cultivated rue Ruta graveolens was introduced from southern Europe later. Rue is common throughout the Middle East, from Syria to Sinai up to the present. Because of its strong smell it is used in cooking and in medicine up to the present. It was used by the Greeks, Romans, and Jews against snakebite and the stings of bees, wasps and scorpions, not to mention its effectiveness against insanity, epilepsy, and even “the evil eye.” In post-biblical Jewish literature rue is called pigam, which is cognate with the Greek pēganon and the Arabic fegan.

Description:

Rue plant (Otto Wilhelm Thomé Flora von Deutschland, Österreich und der Schweiz 1885, via Kurt Stueber)Rue is a small, shrubby plant that produces many branches at ground level, with many yellow flowers and very sharp-smelling leaves. It can reach up to a meter (3 feet) in height.

Special significance:

The ancient Jewish Talmud states that cultivated plants should be tithed. It is possible that the disagreement between Jesus and the Pharisees arose because by New Testament times the people were cultivating rue, dill,

and similar plants that had not been cultivated before, and the Pharisees then applied the laws of the Talmud to these little plants, thus complicating the lives of the common people, while at the same time they ignored issues of justice and compassion.

Translation:

Depending on what translators do with “mint” in LUK 11:42, they may find a cultural substitute for “rue” or a generic phrase for “mint and rue and every herb.” Since the context is not rhetorical and the plant genus is limited to the Middle East, a transliteration of “rue” will be appropriate. Transliterations can be made from the Greek pēganon or from a major language. (The English word rue comes from Old English ruwe, which comes from Latin ruta and Greek rhyte.)